

a little uncomfortable to carry it in the pocket of your jeans. The Intex phones were the lightest at 68 grams each. The Motorolas and Nokias seem extremely rugged, good enough to survive some falls.

The plastic lid of the bleu 250X is one of the most difficult to open, so much so that we once felt we might end up breaking it!

The Motorola W220, the Nokias, and the bleu 450X have easy-to-use interfaces. The MotoFONE F3 has a monochrome alphanumeric display, and navigating the phone is quite difficult because there's no graphical interface. Thankfully, there is voice help that narrates to you what button to press to achieve a certain task (and believe us, this is critically essential with this phone).

The Intex phones have tacky keypads, and this could be tiring if you SMS a lot. The Motorolas have their trademark feather-touch keypads, which are a joy to use. The keys also happen to be placed well apart. The 4-way rocker on the Nokia 2310 seemed flimsy; that on the 2626 seemed a little better.

Basic features

All the mobiles with colour displays have a resolution of 128 x 128 with 65K colours. Both the bleu phones and the Intex infi have better-looking displays. The Intex King has a monochrome display. The most interesting was the MotoFONE F3 with its alphanumeric monochrome display, which is based on a new technology known as "electric ink" or EPD. The display offers high contrast and is easily visible even in bright sunlight.

The Intex infi has the largest phonebook, specified as 1,000 entries, while unofficially, the bleu 450X has the largest phonebook, only limited by the phone memory. In contrast, the bleu 250X can store only 100 numbers. Predictive text



bleu 450X
Trendy and feature-rich

is supported by all the bleu mobiles, Intex infi, Motorola W220, and also the Nokias.

MP3 ringtones are supported by the bleu 450X, Intex infi, and both the Nokias. The rest of the phones can only use inbuilt ringtones. Vibrations are supported by all the phones excluding the Intex King.

GPRS connectivity has been provided with the bleu 450X, Intex infi, Motorola W220, and the Nokia 2626. Java applications are supported by the bleu 450X, Motorola W220, and Nokia 2626.

The bleu 450X is the only phone here that has expandable memory (by means of a microSD slot).

Camera and multimedia

There were only two camera phones in this category: the bleu 450X and the Intex infi. Naturally, these are more expensive, but we included them in this category because the price difference isn't too much.

The bleu 450X has a VGA camera, while the Intex infi is a step ahead with a 1.3-MP camera. These were also the only two phones that support MP3 music playback. FM radio is present on both the Intex phones, both the Nokias, and the Motorola W220.

Extras

The bleu 450X, Intex infi, and Nokia 2626 have voice recorders, which can serve as makeshift memo devices and also record phone conversations.

Again, we didn't test battery life: we'll only state what's been mentioned by the manufacturers. The Motorola W220 has the longest talk time of 6 hours; the MotoFONE F3, just 4.5 hours. The Nokia 2310 has the longest standby time of 6 hours.

The Motorola W220 even has an external indicator display that alerts you about missed calls and SMSes.

Control Your Spending

Many of you are probably shocked each time you receive your mobile bill... no matter how hard you try to curb your bills, you invariably end up in the same situation month after month, wondering where you went wrong. Worse, the bills come with much technical jargon and fine print, and that only adds to the confusion. A close study of your bill is your first step out of this predicament, and we have a few tips for you.

Billing Plans: Choose your billing plan according to your usage pattern. Most mobile service providers have a one-month starter pack that lets you analyse your usage, and service providers even recommend plans that suit you. You can then choose whether you should go with pre-paid or post-paid.

SMS or call? A common misconception is that SMS is always cheaper than a call. With certain talk plans, calls are actually cheaper. Most service providers have mobile-to-mobile plans of 50 paise or less per minute at a nominal monthly rental. This makes it cheaper to make short calls rather than exchanging four to five SMSes that cost a rupee each. Also, a minute's conversation is more effective and efficient than sending even a single SMS!

Whom do you call? Scrutinise your bill to see if you make a lot of calls to subscribers to a particular service provider. If this is the case, it makes sense to switch to that provider; most

providers have subscription plans that provide discounts on same-service-provider calls.

SMS Addicts: If you believe that mobile phones were invented so you could send SMSes, take advantage of special SMS packages, some of which let you send SMSes at just 10 paise each.

Roaming: If you are a frequent traveller (or even if you aren't), it's a good idea to activate national roaming, since this has recently been made rent-free by many providers (check with your provider). Calling landlines while roaming is more expensive than calling to mobiles. Calls are generally cheaper than SMSes in this case as well—SMSes generally cost around Rs 3.50, while calls can cost anywhere between Rs 1.40 and 2.40 depending on the plan.

Here's a note about service providers while you're roaming. For example, if you are a BPL Mobile subscriber in your hometown, manually select the BPL Mobile network in your mobile phone's network settings when you are in a different city. In case that network is unavailable, select an allied network (which you can find on your service provider's Web site). If you use a different network, you could end up paying heavy interconnect charges.

Mobile Internet: Indispensable to many on the move, but it